
The Morning: Desire paths

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The New York Times The Morning

February 14, 2026



Good morning. On Valentine's Day, consider the ways in which we're sticking to established paths — and the places where we yearn to deviate.



María Jesús Contreras

Open road



By **Melissa Kirsch**

After a blizzard in New York City, a pedestrian accustomed to crossing the street mid-block may find herself barricaded in, banks of plowed snow creating a fortress, forcing her to walk the length of the shoveled sidewalk to the crosswalk, as the urban planners intended. Follow the grid, same as everyone else, no shortcuts.

That is, unless someone has, mercifully, carved an incursion into the snow bank, creating a makeshift means of egress, a way out. These unofficial trails that permit deviation from the prescribed route are known as “desire paths.” Desire paths (or, sometimes, “desire lines”) show up after snowstorms, as my colleagues Anna Kodé and Amir Hamja [documented this week](#), but you can find them anywhere humans have decided the official trail is too indirect: Those dirt trails that branch off paved walkways in parks, offering a shorter route from A to B, are desire paths, too. Has there ever been a more romantic name for a traffic pattern? (Maybe there has? In 1978, William Least Heat-Moon published

“Blue Highways,” an account of traveling U.S. back roads — they used to be blue on old highway maps — in his van after the loss of his job and the breakup of his marriage. A heartbreaking title, but desire path still wins, I think.)

The word desire has an ache in it. That’s why its application to a trail deviating from a snowy sidewalk is so affecting — it’s not just that I’d prefer to walk some other way, but I have a deep longing for another way. Imagine the planning commission meeting in which bureaucrats discuss desire paths in between more mundane-sounding plans for rezoning the waterfront and building a bus stop. Desire is so tender, so intimate, so individual.

The metaphor feels too easy: chart your own course, color outside the lines, take the road less traveled (or, rather, create your own road). But when you add the word desire to the equation, the process of deviating from the established route feels more urgent. Desire paths are not just ways to get from one place to another. They’re evidence, over time, that an existing design is not adequate. They “indicate yearning,” a traffic engineer told *The Times* [in 2003](#). There’s something gorgeous about the collective yearning signified by an alternate path through the snow or the lawn — a silent project in which people, over time, express a common desire. When I see a desire path right where I feel the urge to deviate from the official route, I feel connected to the pedestrians who had the same idea, whose desires mirrored my own.

It’s Valentine’s Day, a holiday that’s more closely associated with heart-shaped everything and dinner reservations than it is sincere expressions of emotion. If you’re feeling hemmed in by some established script for the day, why not consider your own desire path? What trail would you prefer to tread? How would you alter the terrain in your own life on an occasion that, while nominally devoted to honoring romance, can feel architected by forces that decided there’s one rose-strewn path we should all be following?

“Desire lines are inherently subversive,” my colleague Anna writes. “They remind us that we have a choice, and that we can veer away from what was laid out for us.” On the map of a life, as on the map of a city, desire lines scar the landscape, those alternate routes we took when we were impelled by yearning to strike out in a different direction. “A man who couldn’t make things go right could at least go,” Heat-Moon wrote in “Blue Highways” of his thinking on the eve of his 13,000-mile road trip. As the snow melts in the city and the physical desire paths go with it, I’m considering the simmering desire, mine and others’, to make new, metaphorical paths, to cut lines through drifts that are walling us in, to create new ways out when the old ones no longer suffice.



THE LATEST NEWS

Immigration

The Department of Homeland Security [has run out of funding](#) as Congress feuds over changes to ICE. But officials say the department's essential functions will continue.

Homeland Security has sent tech companies [hundreds of subpoenas](#) for names and other identifying data behind social media accounts that track or criticize ICE.

Two ICE agents were placed on leave after [video evidence contradicted their story](#) of shooting an immigrant.

In the Courts



The Trump administration [sued Harvard](#), accusing the university of failing to produce records for a federal investigation into discrimination against white applicants.

A Brazilian au pair was [sentenced to 10 years in prison](#) for her role in a lurid double murder in Virginia.

An Indian man pleaded guilty to [orchestrating a failed assassination plot](#) against a Sikh separatist in New York.

Other Big Stories

Allies of Robert F. Kennedy Jr. are working to [repeal state laws that require children to be vaccinated](#) before they enter day care or kindergarten.

Europe and America “belong together,” [Secretary of State Marco Rubio said](#) at the Munich Security Conference, in a speech that echoed the Trump administration’s talking points on the threat of Western decline.

Law enforcement officers [closed off a street](#) about two miles from the home of Nancy Guthrie and said the operation was related to her disappearance.

Overall inflation [unexpectedly eased to 2.4 percent](#) in January, compared with the same time last year.

San Francisco teachers ended their strike. All public schools in the city [will reopen next week for 50,000 students](#).

THE WEEK IN CULTURE

Film and TV



Jacob Elordi in “Wuthering Heights.” Warner Bros. Pictures, via Associated Press

In “Wuthering Heights,” Emily Brontë described Heathcliff as a “dark-skinned gipsy.” In the new film, though, he’s played by Jacob Elordi, a white actor from Australia. The Times [asked Brontë scholars to weigh in](#).

“Neighbors,” a new dark-comic docuseries on HBO, [captures the petty feuds of American life](#) — squabbles over fences, walls and Halloween decorations.

The actor James Van Der Beek died this week at 48. Maya Salam looked at a less heralded era of his career: After aging out of his “young heartthrob” phase, he opened up his home life as a [family man and proud father of six](#).

Stephen Curry makes his animated basketball debut in “Goat.” Our critic says it feels like a souped-up version of “Space Jam” [plopped into the world of “Zootopia.”](#)

How do we decide which television shows to write about, episode by episode? [Our TV editor reveals his strategy](#).

Books

“I wish I knew how to quit you.” Do you know the source of that quote? [Take our quiz and match the literary love lines to the books they came from.](#)

“Little Women” is a lot of things, but it’s not goth. A new version reimagines its characters as [a vampire, a werewolf, a bat-winged creature and a sea monster.](#)

How much do you know about romance literature? In the video below, Jennifer Harlan, an editor at The New York Times Book Review, guides you through her 101-word glossary. Click to watch.



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More Culture

The official portrait from Trump's first term was never unveiled to the public. Now the president [wants the Smithsonian to commission a new](#)

[one](#).

Hear how Tina Turner, Al Green, Beyoncé and other Black musicians have [reinterpreted the Beatles](#).

Grand theft artifact: A new video game, Relooted, [asks players to steal stolen art](#).

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CULTURE CALENDAR



Gabriel Basso in “The Night Agent.” Christopher Saunders/Netflix



By [Alexis Soloski](#)

📺🕵️ **“The Night Agent” (Thursday):** An espionage thriller in the paranoid style, “The Night Agent” returns to Netflix for a third season. Created by Shawn Ryan (“The Shield”), the show stars Gabriel Basso (“Hillbilly Elegy”) as Peter Sutherland, an F.B.I. underling with a habit of stumbling into vast conspiracies and making increasingly questionable choices as he fights his way out of them. It is paradoxically both anti-government and anti-partisan, and often pretty fun, as long as you don’t think too hard. The new season, which also stars Genesis Rodriguez, takes on dark money and campaign finance without stinting on bruising fight scenes or (a personal favorite) people screaming “night action!” into their phones.



RECIPE OF THE WEEK



David Malosh for The New York Times. Food Stylist: Barrett Washburne.

By Melissa Clark

Chocolate Self-Saucing Cake

Happy Valentine's Day to all who celebrate — and to anyone who loves an excuse to bake something with chocolate. If you're looking for a speedy dessert to make for tonight, Yossy Arefi's deeply bittersweet [chocolate self-saucing cake](#) comes together in under an hour with ingredients you probably already have on hand. (Pro tip: You can substitute Greek yogurt for the sour cream.) Serve it warm while the fudgy sauce is at its runniest.

REAL ESTATE



Connie and Rick Harlow in Biloxi, Miss. Edmund D. Fountain for The New York Times

The Hunt: Two empty-nesters returned to Mississippi and looked for a house where relatives and friends could gather. Which did they choose? [Play our game.](#)

What you get for \$2.5 million in California: [A ranch house in San Rafael](#), a Rudolph Schindler design in Los Angeles, or a contemporary waterfront home in Lake Arrowhead.

LIVING



Getty Images

Sleep better with others by trying these solutions for [the most common bed-sharing problems](#).

Protect your privacy when using an [A.I.-powered doorbell camera](#).

ADVICE FROM WIRECUTTER

Is it time for a new mattress?

Before you fork over hundreds or thousands of dollars for a new mattress, you'll want to rule out a couple of things. If you're experiencing aches in your back or neck, you should first consider whether [your pillow could be the culprit](#). If you have a new, supportive mattress that just doesn't feel cushy or soft enough, a [good mattress topper](#) could help. But if your mattress sags visibly or has a

permanent indentation in the shape of your body, it's probably time for a new one. And this is one of the best weekends of the year to upgrade: We've rounded up [the very best Presidents' Day deals](#) on expert-vetted mattresses — and plenty more sleep gear, too.

WINTER OLYMPICS

Men's figure skating: Ilia Malinin, known as the Quad God, [finished eighth](#) in a competition in which he was heavily favored. (See how [stumbles cost him a medal](#).) Kazakhstan's Mikhail Shaidorov, meanwhile, [delivered the skate of his life](#) to take gold.

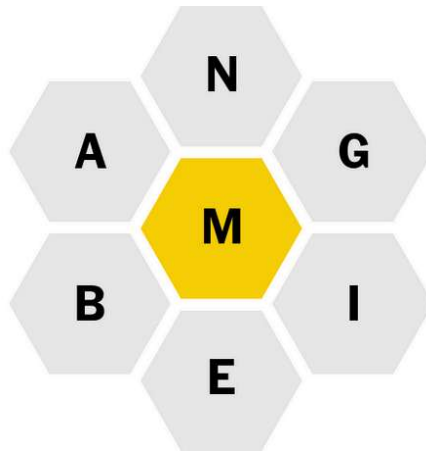
Women's hockey: Team U.S.A. [advanced to the semifinals](#) after defeating Italy, 6-0. The Americans' shutout streak is the longest in Olympic women's hockey history.

Women's snowboarding: Chloe Kim missed out on gold in the halfpipe, finishing second to Gaon Choi of South Korea. We analyzed their runs — [see how Choi came out on top](#).



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NOW TIME TO PLAY



Here is [today's Spelling Bee](#). Yesterday's pangrams were *unevolved* and *unloved*.

[Take the news quiz](#) to see how well you followed this week's headlines.

And here are [today's Mini Crossword](#), [Wordle](#), [Sudoku](#), [Connections](#) and [Strands](#).

***Thanks for spending part of your weekend with The Times. —
Melissa***

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